

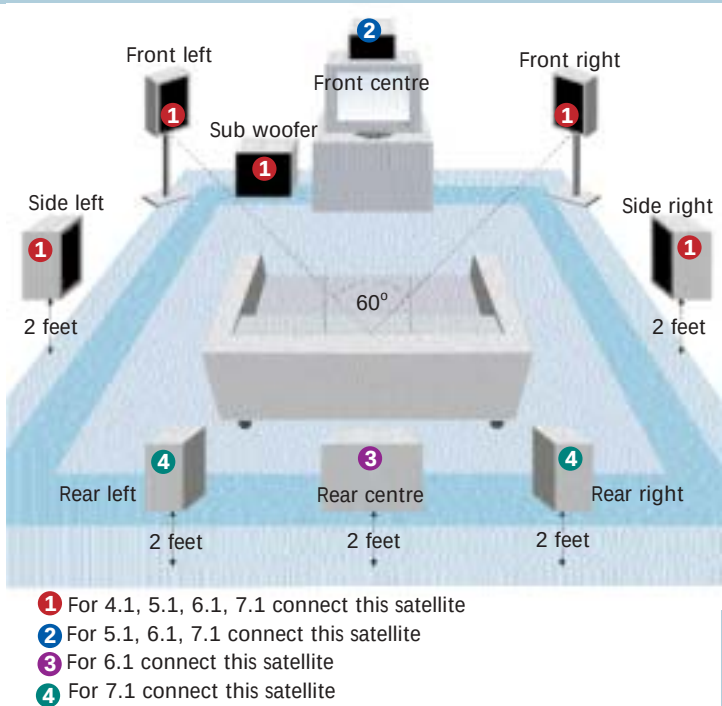
Sound Spots

If you are the only person using the system, make sure that you sit equi-distant from the left, centre and right speakers. If you always have friends over, then arrange the speakers in a straight line. Avoid placing the centre speaker closer to the listeners than the left and right ones.

The left speaker should make an angle of 25 to 30 degrees from the centre, with respect to the listener, as should the right speaker. We recommend a wider angle, with the left and right speakers further apart, if you use your system mainly to listen to music. Also, the three front speakers should be as close as possible to ear-level.

Place the surround speakers alongside and slightly to the rear, but not exactly behind the listener. The surround speakers should be at least about 2 to 3 feet above the listener's head.

As for room acoustics, make sure that there are not too many smooth or hard surfaces that cause reflections. This harshens and muddles the sound. Carpeting and draping is a solution. Avoid rooms that are perfectly square, since they have a noticeable resonant effect. Increase the bass output by placing the sub-woofer at corners formed by the intersection of walls, ceilings and floors.



Decision Maker

	Price conscious	Prudent	Enthusiast
You need	A reasonably good speaker set that offers surround sound functionality with a good balance between performance and price	You want an extremely good sound experience without splurging a lot of money	A system with no-holds-barred performance and state-of the art features plus support for all the latest consumer audio standards. Price no bar; Experience? Out of this world!
Look for	A 4.1 setup that will provide you with an engaging experience without being tough on your pockets	A 5.1 setup that will please your senses but may pinch your budget just a little bit	A setup that will simply amaze you with it's clarity and power
Our pick	Creative Inspire 4400, Artis S400	Altec Lansing 251, Creative Inspire 5200, Odyssey 5.1	The Creative Megaworks 550, Altec Lansing X10, the Creative Inspire 5700D, GD580, or Creative Inspire T6600 6.1
Price	Upto Rs 4,500	Upto Rs 10,000	Above Rs 15,000

Conclusion

With the sound wars done with, not to mention the loss of hearing that we continue to suffer, it's time to reflect on the results.

Sound is a very personal, and subjective thing. What may sound harmonic to one, may be another's nightmare. These tests, and their results, give you an insight on each speaker's quality and overall performance. The lesson learned: A good speaker always sounds better when compared to others. However, that does not mean that the rest are bad! There are a lot of components involved in the whole scene such as the sound card, your room and the speaker placement that are conducive to a good experience.

A surround setup consisting of at least 4.1 speakers is necessary to watch movies, or listen to music. However, that's being phased out as all the channels are mixed to provide the surround experience. 7.1 systems have yet to come of age, and can be considered an overkill, while 6.1 are still being eyed skeptically. Media that will take advantage of such features is yet to be available in the market. And by the time it is, there will be more players in the same segment, and fiercer competition too. The 5.1 setup, at this point of time, is more than enough for your aural senses. Currently, this setup is a point of reference for all home-theatre manufacturers. Thus, it makes sense to opt for a 5.1 today. For the future, there is a lot more to come.